

How we plan and deliver research that matters

ABARES plays a key role in supporting decisions that shape Australia's agriculture, fisheries, forestry, and water sectors. We do this by providing trusted, independent research, data, analysis and advice that helps government and industry respond to current challenges and prepare for future opportunities.

Each year, we work closely with stakeholders across government, industry and research organisations to identify the most important issues likely to affect the sectors over the next three to five years. This helps us set clear priorities for our research and build the skills and tools needed to deliver high-quality insights. It also opens opportunities to collaborate with others who share our goals.

Our annual work plan outlines the major activities we will undertake across five key focus areas. These include producing a wide range of outputs from briefing notes and insights papers to detailed research reports, working papers, and interactive data dashboards. All of these are designed to support informed decision-making and public understanding.

A key part of our mission is making sure our work reaches the right people. The annual ABARES National Outlook conference is our flagship event, bringing together experts from across Australia and around the world to discuss the future of agriculture and related industries. It's a chance to share knowledge, shape policy conversations, and strengthen connections between government, industry, and researchers.

To keep pace with growing demand and complexity, we are also upgrading our technology and data systems. This will improve the security, reliability, and usability of our work, reduce manual processes, and ensure our research continues to meet the highest standards. By modernising our systems, we're investing in the future, so we can keep delivering world-class insights that help Australia's agriculture, fisheries, and forestry sectors thrive.

Priorities for the year ahead

Farm Survey collection to shape smarter policy

ABARES continues to survey broadacre and dairy farms to collect detailed physical, financial, and socioeconomic data. This trusted information helps DAFF monitor industry performance, assess the impact of major events, and evaluate policy responses to ensure decisions are grounded in real-world evidence.

Delivering trusted forecasts to guide agriculture, fisheries and forestry

ABARES will continue producing its flagship quarterly reports: Agricultural Commodities and the Australian Crop Report, to provide up-to-date forecasts on production, prices, and exports across key agricultural, fisheries and forestry sectors. These reports, help government, industry, researchers, and media understand market trends, assess risks and opportunities, and make informed decisions.

Providing key statistics on Australia's farm sector

The Agriculture Commodity Statistics publication delivers consolidated macroeconomic, farm sector, and commodity data that informs analysis, research and decision-making across government, industry, research, and media.

Strengthening the understanding of climate dynamics for agriculture

The Weekly Australian Climate, Water and Agriculture Update delivers timely insights into how seasonal conditions affect agricultural production, water availability, and commodity prices both in Australia and globally. In 2025–26, it will increasingly draw on data from the Australian Agricultural Drought Indicators program.

Driving smarter decisions with farm performance insights

ABARES publishes detailed data and research on farm productivity, financial performance, debt, investment, and the impacts of climate and market shifts to capture the evolving structure of Australian agriculture. These insights directly support DAFF's policy development and evaluation and empower industry stakeholders like Grains Research and Development Corporation and Meat and Livestock Australia to make informed decisions. As we continue to modernise our systems, we are focused on expanding access to this critical information to help shape a more resilient and productive agricultural sector.

Modernising community vulnerability insights for smarter policy

ABARES is refreshing its long-standing Indicators of Community Vulnerability to better support policy and program design across government. By reviewing contemporary approaches and tapping into a broader range of internal and external data sources, we are strengthening the model's ability to reflect current challenges and opportunities. Originally developed to help understand the regions more vulnerable to environmental water recovery under the Basin Plan, these indicators have since informed major initiatives including climate policy, marine reserves, and drought response. Our forward focus is on ensuring it remains a trusted, adaptable tool for evidence-based decision-making.

Modernising regional agricultural statistics for better decisions

ABARES is working with the Australian Bureau of Statistics and other partners to modernise how regional agricultural data is collected, produced, and shared. This includes developing new agricultural water use statistics, strengthening cross-agency coordination through commodity working groups, and improving access to detailed agricultural microdata. By enhancing the quality and availability of regional data, we're enabling more informed decisions across government, industry, and research, supporting a more responsive and data-driven agricultural sector.

Building a clearer picture of Australia's agricultural workforce

ABARES is continuing to deliver insights into the agricultural workforce by collecting and analysing data from the Horticulture Labour Survey and supplementary surveys in the broadacre and dairy sectors. We are producing labour fact sheets, researching the impact of changing remuneration conditions, and exploring labour productivity trends. This work provides a clearer understanding of workforce dynamics and supports informed decision-making across government, industry, and research to help shape policies and strategies that respond to real-world labour challenges in agriculture.

Strengthening Australia's forest data for smarter decisions and global reporting

ABARES is continuously updating the National Forest Inventory to provide reliable, up-to-date data that supports informed decision-making across forest policy, industry, and sustainability. This includes publishing key forest economics data, such as plantation statistics, wood product outputs, gross value of production estimates, and forecasts for major forestry commodities to help policymakers and industry leaders assess current conditions and plan for the future. Through the Australia's State of the Forests reporting process, ABARES integrates ecological, spatial, and tabular data from Commonwealth, state, and territory forest agencies, ensuring the Inventory remains a trusted source for national and international forest reporting. As an Essential Statistical Asset since 1988, the Inventory underpins Australia's commitments under the National Forest Policy Statement, the Regional Forest Agreements Act 2002, and global targets like United Nations Sustainable Development Goal 15. These efforts ensure Australia's forest data remains credible, connected, and accessible to inform forest policy and sustainable forest management.

Producing land use intelligence for sustainable planning

In partnership with the Australian Collaborative Land Use and Management Program (ACLUMP), ABARES will release an updated national compilation of available catchment scale land use mapping in 2026. We are also continuing work to improve national land use and tenure datasets for the National Land Account. Different approaches to mapping agricultural land uses will be evaluated for modernising Australia's agricultural statistics. This work underpins key government initiatives such as the Agriculture and Land Sectoral Plan and the Nature Positive Plan, while supporting critical functions like sustainability planning, biodiversity protection, disaster response, biosecurity, and greenhouse gas modelling. These efforts provide a robust evidence base for evaluating land use trade-offs and shaping future land management strategies.

Enhancing economic understanding to support fisheries management

ABARES is strengthening economic monitoring and performance assessment across Commonwealth fisheries to support more informed and responsive management. A new half-yearly report for the Australian Fisheries Management Authority (AFMA) tracks emerging economic pressures, particularly in fisheries without net economic return estimates, helping managers incorporate timely economic

insights into their decisions. In parallel, ABARES has developed a new method to estimate economic performance using administrative and public data, reducing reliance on traditional surveys. The first application, focused on the Eastern Tuna and Billfish Fishery, will be published as a working paper, with further fisheries to follow. These indicators help evaluate how effectively fisheries are managed under the Fisheries Management Act 1991 and ensure decisions deliver maximum net economic returns to the Australian community.

Unlocking productivity drivers in Australian agriculture

ABARES is publishing insights into the key factors shaping productivity in the agriculture sector, including barriers to growth, the impacts of climate change, and emissions-adjusted productivity estimates. These data products and analyses support DAFF's corporate performance measures and inform policy and industry decisions—helping drive sustainable growth and resilience across the sector.

Forecasting drought impacts to strengthen agricultural resilience

ABARES has developed national indicators that translate climate data into clear, outcome-based measures of drought impacts on the agricultural sector. By combining climate data with agricultural models, these indicators help forecast the extent and severity of drought across the sector. In the next phase, we are operationalising the tool and refining the models to support more targeted decision-making. Developed in collaboration with CSIRO, this tool will help DAFF shape drought policy and enable industry to monitor and prepare for potential impacts to build resilience in the face of growing climate challenges.

Designing smarter water trading for environmental outcomes

ABARES is working with the Commonwealth Environmental Water Holder to develop a practical, evidence-based water trading strategy that aligns with environmental watering goals and navigates the complexities of water markets. In collaboration with the Murray Darling Basin Authority and CSIRO, we will also quantify the environmental benefits of this approach. The strategy will help allocate water where and when it is needed most or redirect resources to other environmental priorities to support healthier rivers and ecosystems and deliver broader benefits to the industries and communities that rely on their sustainability.

Providing economic advice on water policy

ABARES is supporting other government agencies by providing advice on matters such as the impacts of water recovery under the Murray Darling Basin Plan on agriculture and the water market, as well as providing assistance for the upcoming review of the Basin Plan.

Modernising insights into Australia's wood processing sector

Commissioned by Forest and Wood Products Australia (FWPA), ABARES is reviewing the structure of the wood processing sector to deliver more efficient and complete reporting. With declining survey

responses, we are developing a new method to capture up-to-date information on the number of sawmills, production levels, revenue, and sector challenges. This report will track industry trends, identify market inefficiencies, and provide deeper insights into engineered wood products to supporting government program design and helping the sector navigate increasing market complexity both in Australia and globally.

Building a stronger productivity evidence base for Australia's forestry sector

ABARES, commissioned by FWPA, is leading efforts measure productivity for the plantation sector. This will develop a productivity index that provides a consistent framework for measuring how effectively forestry businesses convert inputs into outputs, supported by an ongoing data program. In parallel, ABARES is updating regional Mean Annual Increment and Yield Tables to track changes in plantation performance over the past 10–20 years and highlight regional differences in silviculture. These insights are essential for identifying productivity challenges and opportunities, guiding research and development investment, and informing forest policy and planning, especially as land competition limits expansion and industry dynamics reshape the market for logs.

Helping Australia understand global agricultural trade

ABARES uses two global trade models to study how international trade affects farming. One model looks at how farming and environmental policies work together across different countries. The other model, called AGTAM, helps us understand how changes in trade agreements between countries might impact Australian agriculture. AGTAM was built for a specific purpose and has been updated over time, but requires further maintenance, such as better documentation and technical improvements to enable it to continue supporting clear and reliable advice for government and industry.

Driving smarter, sustainable farming through national insights

The National Agricultural Land Use Management Survey (NALMs) is engaging around 8,000 agricultural land managers across Australia to build a comprehensive picture of how climate-smart practices and sustainable farming are being adopted on the ground. By collecting large-scale data from all agricultural sectors, this survey directly informs policy and program design, guiding future government investments in resilient, resource-efficient agriculture. Using both paper and digital tools, NALMs is laying the groundwork for smarter decisions and stronger support for farmers nationwide.

Unlocking forestry's role in carbon and nature repair markets

Commissioned by FWPA, this consultation-driven report explores why and how forestry industry players and carbon market investors choose to engage with carbon and nature repair markets. It goes beyond theory to uncover the behavioural drivers behind project registration under the plantations method. The findings will guide industry and government stakeholders on shaping future engagement strategies, highlighting how tools like FullCAM and additionality rules influence participation at both national and regional levels.

Informing Australia's position on environmental trade measures

This research will assess global environmental trade measures to guide Australia's agricultural trade policy position. By identifying and quantifying the impacts of trade liberalisation, it will strengthen Australia's efforts to reduce distortions in global agricultural trade and reinforce Australia's position in international negotiations.

Modernising economic modelling for net-zero transitions

This work updates the core database behind ABARES' Global Trade and Environment Model, ensuring modelling advice remains relevant as Australia transitions to net-zero emissions by 2050. By refreshing the data that drives whole-of-economy modelling, including sectoral interactions, it strengthens the foundation for policy design and analysis. This enables government to assess economic and emissions outcomes under different scenarios and make informed decisions in a rapidly evolving global landscape.

Understanding trade policy in a changing climate

This Insights report builds on 2024–25 research to show that open markets consistently deliver stronger outcomes in the face of increasing climate volatility. Using a framework that accounts for uncertainty, it provides a solid evidence base to understand the impact of trade and domestic support policy as climates shift across the world. As climate change intensifies, unpredictable weather events may tempt countries to adopt protectionist policies.

Supporting informed land use and climate policy decisions

This project delivers timely, location-based advice to support DAFF's climate policy reviews, including assessments of Australian Carbon Credit Units Scheme Plantation Forestry Notifications that may affect regional agriculture. It provides expert input to areas across DAFF on land use, soil, and agricultural practices, and supplies spatial analyses to guide responses to natural disasters and biosecurity threats. Through leadership of NCLUMI/ACLUMP, it ensures nationally consistent land use mapping and data standards, enabling place-based decision-making and whole-of-government coordination. These efforts underpin legislated assessments and strengthen Australia's capacity to respond to climate, environmental, and agricultural challenges.

Contributing scientific advice to domestic fisheries management

We participate in AFMA Resource Assessment Group meetings and similar forums as scientific members, invited participants, or observers. In these roles, we represent ABARES and the Department, providing evidence-based scientific advice to support informed and effective fisheries management decisions.

Driving forest science leadership

ABARES will continue to lead national and international forest science efforts by advising DAFF and other agencies on forest-related issues, including production, conservation, health and First Nations participation. By updating and analysing forest data from across jurisdictions, ABARES supports policy development on Regional Forest Agreements, deforestation, biodiversity, and carbon balance. Active engagement in global technical forums and publishing insights via the Forests Australia website reinforces Australia's commitment to sustainable forest management and enhances the department's credibility and influence in forest-related matters.

Scientific leadership in regional fisheries management

We lead Australia's scientific input to five Regional Fisheries Management Organisations, providing expert analysis and advice on stock status, harvest strategies, and sustainable fishing practices. This work supports Australia's international obligations, strengthens its positions in key negotiations, and directly influences regional decisions that protect fish stocks, reduce bycatch, and promote long-term sustainability. It also contributes to Australia's strategic interests in the Indo-Pacific through science-based diplomacy.

Delivering trusted assessments of Australia's fisheries

ABARES produces independent, public reports that assess the health of fish stocks and the economic performance of Commonwealth-managed fisheries, supporting transparency and informed decision-making. Through the annual Fishery Status Reports and contributions to national fish stock reports, ABARES provides robust data and analysis used by the Minister, government agencies, industry, environmental groups, and the public. These reports are widely referenced in policy development, media, and stakeholder engagement, helping communicate the sustainability and performance of Australia's fisheries across jurisdictions.

Shaping the future of sustainable fisheries policy

ABARES is leading the scientific and economic advice to support the Australian Government's five-year review of the Commonwealth Harvest Strategy Policy and the Fisheries Bycatch Policy. These two key policies guide how Commonwealth fisheries are managed to achieve legislated sustainability and economic goals. These policies directly guide and inform decisions of the Australian Fisheries Management Authority.

Delivering trusted data on Australia's forests

We provide up-to-date, authoritative information on Australia's forests, including their extent, condition, and resources across public, private, and Indigenous lands, to support sustainable forest management. In 2025–26, we will complete updates to all 44 national indicators under Australia's Sustainable Forest Management Framework. This data underpins evidence-based policy, supports forest-related programs and assessments, and helps demonstrate Australia's commitment both

domestically and internationally to ecologically sustainable forest management and a strong, renewable forest products industry.

Models and methods for smarter biosecurity inspections and surveillance

This work develops tools and methodologies to improve how Australia detects and responds to biosecurity threats, such as using group testing for more efficient inspections and building decision-making frameworks for pest and disease control. Through partnerships with the Australian National University, the Centre of Excellence for Biosecurity Risk Analysis (CEBRA), CSIRO, and the Arthur Rylah Institute, these approaches are helping deliver better decisions, more efficient resource use, and stronger protection for agriculture and the environment.

Economic models to guide biosecurity investment

This work focuses on developing and applying economic models and methods to help make smarter decisions about where to invest resources in biosecurity. By using detailed cost-benefit analyses, especially during emergency responses, it provides evidence of the financial risks posed by pests and diseases and the value of actions taken to prevent or control them. These insights support informed decisions about whether to start, continue, or adjust biosecurity programs and policies, helping ensure resources are used effectively to protect Australia's agriculture and environment.

Supporting national policy on environmental biosecurity

This work helps shape national policy on exotic pests, weeds, and diseases by providing research, tools, and expert advice to support decision-making and assist informed, coordinated responses to emerging threats. It strengthens preparedness for invasive species through risk assessments and practical methodologies and offers technical input and committee representation to the Australian Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer.

National insights on established pests and weeds

This work supports national policy on established vertebrate pests and weeds by collecting and analysing data on their presence, impact, and management across Australia. Key projects include mapping the distribution of priority species, surveying landholders to track changes in pest and weed issues over time, and contributing to the National Established Weed Priorities Framework. These efforts provide the evidence base for coordinated management decisions and help identify species that may need national attention.

Improving marine pest biosecurity

This work supports national marine biosecurity by providing scientific advice, data, and tools to help prevent and respond to marine pest incursions. It includes modelling ballast water risks, mapping pest and disease distribution, tracking shipping traffic, and offering technical input and committee

representation. These efforts help guide policy, improve preparedness, and support coordinated responses to protect Australia's marine environments.

Improving general surveillance through monitoring and evaluation

This work supports the effectiveness of general surveillance programs by developing tools to monitor and evaluate their performance. It helps teams improve through adaptive management and provides data on cost-effectiveness. When combined across programs, these insights reveal which approaches work best in different situations to support smarter decisions about where to invest in biosecurity surveillance.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/abares/about/2025-26-work-plan>